Accessing Environment Data

Another conventional way of controlling program behavior is through a shell's *environment*. This is simply a table of key/value pairs; the key name is usually referred to as a *shell variable* (or *shell var* for short), and these can be viewed with on most *nix shells with the `env` command:

```
$ env
TERM_PROGRAM=Apple_Terminal
TERM=xterm-256color
SHELL=/bin/bash
...
```

Shells can make use of these using variable syntax, which is similar to PHP's: just put a `$` character in front of the variable name:

```
$ echo $TERM
xterm-256color
```

All PHP SAPIs are able to access the environment of a process through the `getenv()` function. If the `variables_order` directive contains an `E` character, the `$_ENV` superglobal is also populated (the exact output will vary according to your system and settings):

```
var_dump(getenv());
var_dump(getenv('PHP_VERSION'));
```

```
Output:
array(15) {
  ["HOSTNAME"]=>
  string(12) "4d81e666b865"
  ["PHP_INI_DIR"]=>
  string(18) "/usr/local/etc/php"
  ...
string(6) "8.3.10"
```